



BY CAROLINE COUSIN

French Café *Etiquette*

10 Things Every Visitor Should Know
Before Ordering Coffee in France

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in Paris*

1 Always say "Bonjour" first.

Always greet the staff before you order — before you say anything at all. In France, not saying "Bonjour" is not just impolite; it's almost invisible. You simply don't exist yet.

CULTURAL NOTE

Even in a busy café, a genuine "Bonjour" changes everything. The Parisians aren't cold — they're just formal. Unlock the warmth with a smile and a greeting.

 **SOUND LIKE A LOCAL** *Bonjour, s'il vous plaît.* — Hello, please.

2 Don't expect free refills.

In France, you pay for each coffee separately. The concept of "free refills" doesn't exist — and that's not a flaw. One perfect espresso, sipped slowly, is the Parisian philosophy.

CULTURAL NOTE

Quality over quantity. A café in Paris is not about volume — it's about the ritual. If you want another, simply order one. The waiter won't be surprised.

3 Sit down if you want table service.

In most French cafés, there are two prices: the *prix au comptoir* (at the counter) and the *prix en salle* (at a table). The table is slightly more expensive — because someone will come to you.

CULTURAL NOTE

If you sit down, don't go to the counter to order. Wait for the server. It's a different experience — slower, more relaxed, and very Parisian.



SOUND LIKE A LOCAL *Sur place ou à emporter ?* — For here or to go?

4 Don't rush.

The French café is not a pit stop — it's a destination. Linger is not just accepted, it's expected. No one will hurry you. No one will check if you need anything every five minutes.

CULTURAL NOTE

Your table is yours for as long as you want it. Stay an hour with one espresso. Watch the street. Read. This is not wasting time — this is living like a Parisian.

5

Ask politely for the bill.

The bill in France is never brought automatically. This is intentional — the waiter will not interrupt your moment. When you're ready, catch their eye and say it politely.

CULTURAL NOTE

Don't snap your fingers. Don't call "garçon" — that's outdated and rude. A simple eye contact and a polite phrase is all it takes.

 **SOUND LIKE A LOCAL** *L'addition, s'il vous plaît.* — The bill, please.

6

Tipping is optional.

Service is always included in the price in France (*service compris*). Leaving a tip is a gesture of appreciation, not an obligation. Small coins left on the table are perfectly appropriate.

CULTURAL NOTE

Leaving 50 cents to 1 euro is generous and appreciated. Leaving nothing is completely normal. Never feel pressured.

7 Know your coffee.

Ordering "a coffee" in France means *un café* — a small, strong espresso. If you want something larger or milder, you need to be specific. Here's the basics:

COFFEE GUIDE

Un café = espresso · Un café allongé = americano (more water) · Un café crème = coffee with steamed milk ·
Un noisette = espresso with a dash of cream

 **SOUND LIKE A LOCAL** *Un café, s'il vous plaît.* — A coffee, please.

8 Respect the atmosphere.

French cafés have their own quiet code of conduct. Loud conversations, phones on speaker, or overly boisterous behaviour stand out. Observe first, then adapt.

CULTURAL NOTE

Lower your voice slightly. Look around you. The café is a shared, semi-private space — a place for thought and conversation at a human volume. You'll feel the mood immediately.

9 Terrace or inside?

The *terrasse* is the quintessential Parisian experience — facing the street, watching the world go by. Inside is cozier, quieter, and often preferred in winter or for a more intimate conversation.

CULTURAL NOTE

Choose the *terrasse* to feel the most Parisian. Face outward. Observe. The café is theatre — and you have the best seat.

 **SOUND LIKE A LOCAL** *En terrasse, s'il vous plaît.* — On the terrace, please.

10 Enjoy the moment.

The French café is never really about the coffee. It's about the pause. The brief suspension of everything else. Sit. Breathe. Let Paris come to you.

THE PARISIAN SECRET

On prend le temps. We take our time. This is perhaps the most French idea there is — and the café is where it lives. Carry it home with you.



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